

Chapter 36: The Space He Doesn't Fill

Jenny didn't realize she had been waiting for him until he didn't arrive.

Not late.

Not slightly off schedule.

He simply didn't come.

The realization didn't hit all at once.

It arrived in pieces.

First, the empty table.

Then the lack of his usual silence near the counter.

Then the way her attention kept drifting toward the door without permission.

By noon, she stopped pretending she wasn't noticing.

By afternoon, she stopped pretending it didn't matter.

"Again?" Bao asked.

Jenny didn't look up.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"You checked the entrance."

"I didn't."

"You did."

Jenny tightened her grip on the cloth in her hands.

"Stop tracking me."

Bao leaned on the counter.

"I'm not tracking you. I'm observing."

Jenny shot him a look immediately.

"Don't."

He smiled.

"Too late."

She exhaled sharply and walked away.

But the silence followed her.

It always did now.

At 3:18 p.m., her phone finally buzzed.

Her body reacted before her mind did again.

She hated that most of all.

A message.

From Austin.

Only three words.

Busy today.

That was it.

No explanation.

No apology.

No follow-up.

Jenny stared at the screen longer than she wanted to admit.

Busy today.

Of course.

He always had a world she didn't fully see.

She locked her phone.

Then unlocked it again.

Then locked it again.

Ridiculous.

Completely ridiculous.

That evening, the restaurant felt louder than usual.

Or maybe she was just noticing it more.

Jenny moved through work on autopilot.

Orders.

Tables.

Smiles.

Repetition.

But every pause between tasks felt longer.

He wasn't there to fill them.

And she hated how she had started relying on that without realizing it.

After closing, Jenny stayed behind longer than usual.

Bao noticed but didn't comment.

For once.

She wiped the same counter three times.

Not because it was dirty.

Because stopping meant thinking.

And thinking meant him.

Eventually, Bao spoke softly.

"You're doing it again."

Jenny didn't look up.

"I'm cleaning."

"No," he said gently.

"You're avoiding."

That made her pause.

Then she sighed.

"...He didn't come today."

"I noticed."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"That's it?"

"What do you want me to say?"

"I don't know," she admitted.

That honesty slipped out before she could stop it.

Bao leaned slightly forward.

"Do you want him here?"

Jenny opened her mouth.

Closed it.

That hesitation said everything.

Bao nodded slowly.

"Yeah," he said softly.

"That's new for you."

Jenny shook her head immediately.

"It's not like that."

But her voice didn't sound convincing anymore.

Even to herself.

Later, as she walked home alone, the city felt different again.

Not empty.

Just unbalanced.

Like something familiar had been removed and the world hadn't adjusted yet.

She passed a small café where couples sat near the window.

Laughter.

Warmth.

Ordinary intimacy.

Jenny looked away quickly.

Too familiar.

Too sharp.

When she reached her apartment, she didn't turn on the lights immediately.

She stood by the window instead.

The city below moved without her.

Life continuing normally.

Without interruption.

Without him.

That thought should have comforted her.

It didn't.

Because instead of relief...

she felt the absence more clearly than ever.

Her phone buzzed again.

She grabbed it immediately this time.

A message.

Austin.

I'm back tomorrow.

Jenny stared at it.

Only two sentences.

And yet her chest tightened in a way she didn't want to name.

She typed something.

Deleted it.

Typed again.

Deleted again.

Finally, she just replied:

Okay.

Simple.

Safe.

Neutral.

But after she sent it, she didn't put the phone down.

She just held it.

Waiting for a response that didn't come.

And that silence...

felt louder than the entire day combined.

Because now she understood something she hadn't before:

It wasn't just that he had become part of her routine.

It was that his absence had started rearranging her emotions.

And that was no longer something she could ignore.